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Philemon

Philemon 1:1

Section 1–3: Paul and Timothy greet Philemon
When Christians in New Testament times wrote a letter, they usually started by doing three things. First they wrote the name of the person or people who were writing the letter. Then they wrote the name of the person or people who would be receiving the letter. Then they wrote a Christian greeting. Paul did all three things in his letter to Philemon. He included:

- The name of the person who wrote the letter: Paul (verse 1)
- The name of the person receiving the letter: Philemon (verse 1)
- A Christian greeting (verse 3)

Your translation may be easier to read if each of these three parts is a separate paragraph, as in the GNT, BSB, NIV, and RSV versions.

Carefully consider the best way to arrange the information in verses 1–3 when you translate verses 1–3. What is the usual way to begin a letter in your language? Can you follow that style and still include the three parts from Paul's opening Section? All of the information in this opening Section should also be in the opening Section of your translation. For example, do not take Paul's name out of the opening paragraph even though writers in your language put their name at the end of the letter. After you have decided what is the best way to begin a letter in your language, follow that same basic way consistently in your translations of all of Paul's letters.

Read verses 1–3 carefully in the BSB and the GNT. Then read the following notes and the Display before you begin to translate.

1a
Paul, a prisoner of Christ Jesus,

- ¶ This letter is from me, Paul. I am in prison because I preach about Jesus Christ.

Paul: The apostle Paul wrote this letter. He began by writing his name. There is no verb in verse 1 in the Greek text. But many languages require complete sentences, so you may need to add a verb. Paul was writing a letter to Philemon, so you could use a form of the verb "write" or the verb "greet."

It is not natural in some languages for someone to talk about himself in the third person. For example, it would not be correct in some languages for Paul to write, "Paul is writing to you." In such cases, you could translate this in a first person form:

I, Paul, am writing this letter.

a prisoner of Christ Jesus: Paul was saying, "I am in prison because I do the work of Christ Jesus." GNT: "A prisoner for the sake of Christ Jesus." Paul was in prison when he wrote this letter. But that was not because he did something wrong. People put him in prison because he preached the Good News about Jesus Christ. Those who didn't believe in Jesus Christ didn't like Paul's message, and so they put him in prison.

Christ Jesus: Paul and other authors who wrote New Testament books usually wrote "Jesus Christ" as Paul did in verse 3, instead of the name *Christ Jesus*, which Paul wrote here. The meaning is the same either way. If people who read your translation will think that *Christ Jesus* is a different person from "Jesus Christ," you should use the more common order "Jesus Christ" here also.

1b
and Timothy our brother, To Philemon

- I and our(incl) fellow believer Timothy greet you, Philemon.
- Greetings to you, Philemon, from our Christian brother Timothy and from me.

Timothy: Timothy also sent Philemon his greetings. Timothy was Paul's close friend who worked for Jesus just as Paul did. Bible scholars think that Timothy probably did not help Paul write this letter. But he was with Paul at the time Paul wrote the letter, and he also wanted to greet Philemon.

brother: The word *brother* in this context refers to a fellow believer in Christ. Paul, Timothy and Philemon were probably not physically related to each other as members of the same earthly family are. Timothy was a younger Christian, a fellow believer of Paul and also of Philemon and the other Christians at Colosse.

The word *brother* as used among Christians means that they are spiritual brothers and sisters because they are God's children. They are closely related to one another in this sense. Perhaps you can use the term "brother" for men who are Christians and "sister" for women who are Christians (as in verse 2). Or perhaps there is a word that you could use to include both men and women (such as "sibling" in English). If your language has different words for "older brother" and "younger brother," use "younger brother" here in verse 1 because Timothy was younger than both Paul and Philemon. If "brother" means only a member of the same family in your language and no one will understand a spiritual relationship here, a footnote could explain how Christians used the term then. Or perhaps there may be another term you can use to show how one family member is related to another family member.

To Philemon: This means "We greet you, Philemon." This was a way people wrote letters in Paul's time. Philemon, who received the letter, understood the implied meaning "we send greetings."

Philemon: Philemon was the main person Paul was writing this letter to. Philemon, who lived in the town of Colosse, was an important man and was probably rich. He was also the master of the slave Onesimus. Paul had helped Philemon to become a Christian (see verse 19b).

1c
our beloved fellow worker,

- You are a dear friend and you work for Christ like we(dual excl) do.

our beloved: Both Paul and Timothy loved Philemon very much. You could translate the phrase *our beloved* as "We love you very much." See Display for verse 1c.

fellow worker: The phrase *fellow worker* means that Philemon helped to spread the Good News, like Paul and Timothy did. He probably did not work together with Paul in the same place.

Philemon 1:2

Section 1–3: Paul and Timothy greet Philemon
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2
to Apphia…Archippus…the church: Paul included these people's names in the list of the people he was greeting, but he wrote the letter mainly to Philemon. Beginning at verse 4, Paul wrote directly to Philemon. Even if your translation addresses Philemon in the second person ("to you, Philemon"), perhaps you should refer to these people in the third person. For example, "We send greetings to Apphia…," or "Give our greetings to Apphia…."

2a
to Apphia our sister,

- We(dual excl) also greet Apphia, who is our(incl) fellow believer.
- Greetings to Apphia, who is like a sister to us.(incl)

sister: Paul also greeted Apphia. The phrase "Apphia our sister" means that Apphia was a believer in Christ as Paul was. She did not have the same father or mother as Paul and Philemon. See the note on "brother" in verse 1b.

2b
to Archippus our fellow soldier,

- We(dual excl) also greet Archippus, who strongly preaches the Good News with us.(incl)

fellow soldier: Paul also greeted Archippus. The phrase *Archippus our fellow soldier* implies that Archippus spoke out bravely for Christ when people were against the Good News, like a soldier fights to protect his country. (Colossians 4:17, 1 John 2:14) But there is nothing to indicate that Archippus was a soldier in any earthly army.

2c
and to the church that meets at your house:

- We(dual excl) also greet the other Christians who worship God at your house.

church: Paul also greeted the believers that met in Philemon's house. They met together with Philemon regularly to worship the Lord. Christians didn't have church buildings in those days. They met in homes. See "church", sense 1 in *Key Biblical Terms*.

your house: This refers to Philemon's home.

Philemon 1:3

Section 1–3: Paul and Timothy greet Philemon
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the name of the person or people who were writing the letter. Then they wrote the name of the person or people who would be receiving the letter. Then they wrote a Christian greeting. Paul did all three things in his letter to Philemon. He included:

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Read verses 1–3 carefully in the BSB and the GNT. Then read the following notes and the Display before you begin to translate.

3
Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ.

- May God our(incl) Father and Jesus Christ our Lord bless you(plur) and cause you to have peace in your hearts.

Grace and peace to you from God our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ: Many Christians greeted one another in this way (verse 3) in the early days of Christianity. It is as if Paul was saying a prayer, asking God to bless those he was writing to.

Grace and peace: This was a greeting and blessing Paul often used in his letters. (For example, 1 Corinthians 1:3, Galatians 1:3, Ephesians 1:2).

Grace: The word *Grace* in this context means "kindness, favor, good will, or blessing." Paul was asking God to be kind to those to whom he was writing. He wanted God to favor them. Try to think of ways in your language for asking God to bless someone. The term *Grace* is an important term in the New Testament. See "grace", sense A2(b) in *Key Biblical Terms*.

peace: Paul meant "peace of heart" here. This results from a person having peace with God. The term *peace* also implies "peace with one another." People who have peace of heart normally live in peace with one another.

to you: The word *you* is plural here and thus includes all the people whom Paul addressed in the first two verses.

God our Father: For Christians, God is like a father, one who loves us and cares for us.

Lord: The word *Lord* here in verse 3 means "master" or "leader." Jesus Christ is our spiritual leader. We who are Christians should obey him as a servant obeys his master. See "Christ", sense 4 in *Key Biblical Terms* .

Philemon 1:4

Section 4–7: Paul thanks God for Philemon and prays for him

After Paul greeted Philemon and his friends, Paul thanked God for him and prayed for him. This is the way he started most of his letters. For other examples, see Philippians 1:3–11 and Colossians 1:3–14. Before he asked Philemon to do something, Paul wanted to tell Philemon how much he loved and respected him. Paul thanked God because Philemon had faith in the Lord Jesus, and because he loved God's people. This love gave Paul great joy. And Paul prayed that Philemon's fellowship with other believers would increase and deepen because he (Philemon) knows the good things that God has given believers.

In this Section Paul wrote directly to Philemon. He used only "you (sing)" in verses 4–21, not "you (plur)" as he did in the beginning and end of the letter.

Read verses 4–7 carefully in the BSB and the GNT, and then read the following notes before translating.

4
I always thank my God, remembering you in my prayers,

- ¶ Whenever I pray for you, I always thank God, whom I worship, for you.
- ¶ Whenever I pray for you, I always thank God for you—the God whom I worship.

Verse 4 could have one of two meanings:

1. Every time I pray for you I thank God (for you) (NIV, NCV, CEV, RSV, NLT). This means that Paul did not thank God for Philemon every time he prayed.
2. Every time I pray I thank God for you. (GNT, KJV, JBP, JB). This means that Paul did thank God for Philemon every time he prayed.

The first meaning is probably what Paul intended.

my God: This means "The God I know and belong to and worship." Paul related to God in a very personal way. But a literal translation of the phrase "my God" may imply a wrong meaning in some languages. Check carefully on this point.

remembering: Paul meant that when he prayed he "mentioned" Philemon to God, he "prayed for" him. Be careful not to use a word that would imply he had forgotten Philemon and then remembered him.

Philemon 1:5

Section 4–7: Paul thanks God for Philemon and prays for him

After Paul greeted Philemon and his friends, Paul thanked God for him and prayed for him. This is the way he started most of his letters. For other examples, see Philippians 1:3–11 and Colossians 1:3–14. Before he asked Philemon to do something, Paul wanted to tell Philemon how much he loved and respected him. Paul thanked God because Philemon had faith in the Lord Jesus, and because he loved God's people. This love gave Paul great joy. And Paul prayed that Philemon's fellowship with other believers would increase and deepen because he (Philemon) knows the good things that God has given believers.

In this Section Paul wrote directly to Philemon. He used only "you (sing)" in verses 4–21, not "you (plur)" as he did in the beginning and end of the letter.

Read verses 4–7 carefully in the BSB and the GNT, and then read the following notes before translating.

5

because I hear about your faith in the Lord Jesus and your love for all the saints.

- I do this because people tell me that you continue to believe in the Lord Jesus and that you love all of God's people.

Paul himself had led Philemon to believe in the Lord Jesus. So Paul was thanking God, apparently because people had told him that Philemon continued to trust in the Lord Jesus and that he loved all God's people. The word "because" (BSB) shows that the reason Paul thanked God for Philemon (verse 4) was that Philemon trusted in Christ and loved Christ's people (verse 5).

In the RSV it is not clear how the words *love*, *faith*, *Jesus*, and *saints* go together. In the BSB, NIV and CEV the meaning is clear. For example:

> …the faith you have in the Lord Jesus and the love you have for all God's people.

your faith in the Lord Jesus: You could restate this as "You believe in the Lord Jesus."

faith: The word *faith* means "belief" or "trust." Paul was glad to hear that Philemon continued to believe that the Lord Jesus was the Messiah. And Philemon trusted the Lord Jesus to save him from the punishment for sinning and to give him power not to sin.

your love for all the saints: Using an active verb expresses this more clearly: "You love all the saints."

love: The Greek word *agapē* here refers to one person loving another or others. Philemon truly loved God's people.

saints: The Greek word *hagious* (literally "holy ones") in this verse refers to Christians, those who belong to God. See "holy", sense A3(a) in *Key Biblical Terms*.

Philemon 1:6

Section 4–7: Paul thanks God for Philemon and prays for him

After Paul greeted Philemon and his friends, Paul thanked God for him and prayed for him. This is the way he started most of his letters. For other examples, see Philippians 1:3–11 and Colossians 1:3–14. Before he asked Philemon to do something, Paul wanted to tell Philemon how much he loved and respected him. Paul thanked God because Philemon had faith in the Lord Jesus, and because he loved God's people. This love gave Paul great joy. And Paul prayed that Philemon's fellowship with other believers would increase and deepen because he (Philemon) knows the good things that God has given believers.

In this Section Paul wrote directly to Philemon. He used only "you (sing)" in verses 4–21, not "you (plur)" as he did in the beginning and end of the letter.

Read verses 4–7 carefully in the BSB and the GNT, and then read the following notes before translating.

6

I pray that your partnership in the faith may become effective as you fully acknowledge every good thing that is ours in Christ.

- I pray that the fellowship which you have with those, who believe as you do, may increase/deepen, through your knowing all the good things that God has given us.(incl) May this happen for the glory of Christ.
- I pray that the fellowship which you have with those people who believe in Christ as you believe in him would increase and deepen. I pray that this would be the result of your learning about all the good things that God has given us.(incl) I want this to happen for the glory of Christ.
- I pray that you may fellowship more and more with those who believe, and that you may know all the good things

that God has given us.(incl) I pray this so that people will honor Christ.

(Literal Greek translation:) **that the sharing of your faith may become effective in the knowledge of every good thing in us in Christ:** There are various ways to interpret this verse and, as a result, different English versions have translated it differently.

The interpretation of the first part of the verse depends on several interrelated questions:

How is the word *koinōnia* "fellowship, sharing" to be understood?

Who are the participants in each event? That is, with whom is Philemon sharing in believing? Is it with other Christians (later including Onesimus) or is it with Paul (and Timothy)?

What is the connection between "may become active" and "in/by knowledge"? Does the phrase "in the knowledge of every good thing" describe the means by which that fellowship or sharing becomes effectual, or is the knowledge of every good thing the result of that fellowship/sharing?

Here are three alternative interpretations that seem the most likely, out of several possibilities that commentators have suggested:

1. That *sharing* (Greek: *koinōnia*) refers to sharing, or bonding, with others who believe the same truths. English Bible versions often translate *koinōnia* as "fellowship" when it has this sense. In this interpretation the meaning is that Paul was praying that Philemon would have active fellowship with other believers as he came to understand every good thing that God had done for (or in) God's people. In this interpretation the words "in the knowledge of every good thing" refer to the means by which this fellowship or bonding would happen. *This fits well with the theme of the letter. Paul was about to appeal to Philemon to be merciful toward his runaway slave, Onesimus, because now they both believed in Christ. Although Paul had not yet mentioned his request to Philemon to forgive Onesimus, he was looking forward to the fellowship that Philemon would have with Onesimus. This would happen because they both now recognized God's goodness to them.*
2. That *Sharing* means that Philemon shared his faith with others, that is, he told other people about the gospel message he believed. (NIV and CEV follow this interpretation.) So the phrase "in the knowledge of every good thing" could refer to the result of sharing his faith. There is more than one way to interpret what this result might be. NIV interprets this to mean that Paul prayed that, as Philemon told others about what he believed, Philemon would gain "a full understanding of every good thing we have in Christ." CEV interprets this to mean that Paul prays that as Philemon tells others about what he believes, those people "will come to know all the blessing Christ has given believers."
3. That *Sharing* means "fellowship" as in the first interpretation, but here in verse 6 it is the fellowship Paul and Timothy had with Philemon that is in focus. The words "in the knowledge of every good thing" refer to the results of Philemon's fellowship with Paul and Timothy. Thus GNT interprets the meaning of Paul's prayer to be that, as Philemon had fellowship with Paul and Timothy, Philemon would understand more deeply all the blessings they had as they lived in union with Christ.

There are also other possible interpretations of this verse. However, the first interpretation seems to fit best with the purpose of the letter. Paul was preparing Philemon for something he was about to ask Philemon to do on behalf of their fellow believer, Onesimus. Paul was probably thinking about how Philemon could help Onesimus. He was preparing Philemon by asking him to think about the good things God had given all Christians and by urging him to act for Christ's honor. Remembering these facts would cause Philemon to have closer fellowship with all Christians, including his slave, Onesimus, who had recently become a Christian.

There is yet another problem that you need to consider. Different versions translate the Greek phrase *eis Christon* at the end of the verse (among other ways) as "in Christ," "for Christ," or "to Christ." There are two interpretations of how the word *eis* functions in this verse:

1. The Greek word *eis* relates to the Greek verb that the literal English version above translates "become effective." This would mean that the purpose for becoming effective is to honor Christ. If you agree with this interpretation, you might restate the phrase *in Christ* this way: "May this happen for the sake of Christ," or "This will bring honor to Christ," or "This will cause people to praise Christ." JB, NASB and the Amplified Bible follow this interpretation (1).
2. The Greek word *eis* relates to the phrase "every good thing." Thus the whole phrase would imply "all the good things that are ours because we are in union with Christ," or "because we believe in Christ." The BSB, NIV and GNT follow this interpretation (2).

There is also a textual problem in this verse. In place of *en hēmin* 'in us,' some ancient Greek manuscripts have *en humin* 'in you.' However the weight of the manuscript evidence seems to support *en hēmin*. Also the UBS Greek New Testament 4th edition rates this reading as a B (very probable) degree of certainty. Of the major English versions, only the KJV and the NASB follow the reading *en humin*.

The Display (first Meaning Line) for verse 6 shows a translation of verse 6 that follows interpretation (1) above:

> I pray that the fellowship which you have with those who believe as you do may increase/deepen, through your knowing all the good things that God has given us (incl). May this happen for the glory of Christ.

The notes on "fellowship", sense A2 in *Key Biblical Terms* support this interpretation

Or, if you choose interpretation (2) above for verse 6, you could translate the whole verse as follows:

> I pray that you may be active in sharing your faith, so that you will come to understand fully all the good things God has given us(incl), and that this will result in people glorifying Christ.

Philemon 1:7

Section 4–7: Paul thanks God for Philemon and prays for him

After Paul greeted Philemon and his friends, Paul thanked God for him and prayed for him. This is the way he started most of his letters. For other examples, see Philippians 1:3–11 and Colossians 1:3–14. Before he asked Philemon to do something, Paul wanted to tell Philemon how much he loved and respected him. Paul thanked God because Philemon had faith in the Lord Jesus, and because he loved God's people. This love gave Paul great joy. And Paul prayed that Philemon's fellowship with other believers would increase and deepen because he (Philemon) knows the good things that God has given believers.

In this Section Paul wrote directly to Philemon. He used only "you (sing)" in verses 4–21, not "you (plur)" as he did in the beginning and end of the letter.

Read verses 4–7 carefully in the BSB and the GNT, and then read the following notes before translating.

7a

I take great joy and encouragement in your love,

- I am very happy and encouraged because you love others!
- The way that you love others has caused me to be very happy and has encouraged me.

Some translations use a connecting word at the beginning of this verse to show that verse 7 is another reason why Paul thanked God. See also verse 4. For example:

> For (RSV)

your love: Philemon was showing that he loved God's people. This refers to the love that Paul thanked God for in verse 5.

encouragement: When Philemon showed that he loved God's people, it helped to strengthen Paul's ability to trust God and it helped to comfort him while he was in prison.

7b

because you, brother, have refreshed the hearts of the saints.

- You, my fellow believer, have encouraged God's people!

because you, brother, have refreshed the hearts of the saints: Paul was very happy because Philemon had caused God's people to be happy.

because: Paul was thinking about a specific way that Philemon had showed God's people that he loved them when he mentioned Philemon's love in 7a. Verse 7b explains what specific way of showing love Paul was thinking about in 7a.

brother: See the note on verse 1b.

refreshed: (GNT:) "cheered." This means when someone causes someone else to rest, to feel better, to be happy, to have new courage, to be encouraged.

the hearts of the saints: This refers to the way God's people felt in their inner selves, in their souls.

General Comment on 1:7

Here are two different ways to translate verse 7:

> My brother, you love God's people and you have made them happy. This gives me great joy and comfort.

> Brother, you love your fellow believers there and it causes me to feel great joy. It has also strengthened my faith because you have caused God's people to be happy.

Philemon 1:8

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave

This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved

Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

In this Section (verses 8–21) Paul, as a Christian brother, asked Philemon to help Onesimus, but did not command him to do it.

Read verses 8–21 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 8–11 Paul appeals to Philemon on behalf of Onesimus

Read verses 8–11 again, then read the following notes before you translate.

8

So although in Christ I am bold enough to order you to do what is proper,

- ¶ I ask you to do something that you should do. I could use the authority Christ has given me to command you to do this, but I won't.
- ¶For this reason I ask you to do the right thing as a Christian. I could be bold as Christ's apostle and order you to do it.

So: "For this reason" (GNT). This means that the words in verse 7 are the reason for what Paul said in 8–9a. He was thinking like this: Therefore (since Philemon loves his Christian brothers,) he should also love Onesimus. But Paul did not yet make all of this meaning explicit.

in Christ: There are two ways of understanding the meaning of the phrase *in Christ*:

1. As an apostle of Christ, Paul had authority from Christ to command Philemon to do this.
2. As a Christian brother, Paul had a close relationship with Philemon that freed him to tell Philemon to do this. GNT follows this interpretation by translating this "as your brother in Christ."

The following phrase in the BSB is: *I am bold enough to order you* . So the first interpretation fits better with this idea of giving an order in contrast to asking him to do something.

bold: The word *bold* means "not afraid." Paul was not afraid to say whatever he should say.

order: To *order* someone means to command him. It means to tell someone to do something. As an apostle of Christ, Paul could have told Philemon to help Onesimus. But Paul decided it was better to ask him, as a friend and a fellow Christian.

to do what is proper: This refers to what Paul thought Philemon should do in order to act as a Christian should act. What Paul implied here was that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. But Paul did not say this openly until verse 17.

Philemon 1:9

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave

This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

In this Section (verses 8–21) Paul, as a Christian brother, asked Philemon to help Onesimus, but did not command him to do it.

Read verses 8–21 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 8–11 Paul appeals to Philemon on behalf of Onesimus

Read verses 8–11 again, then read the following notes before you translate.

9a

I prefer to appeal on the basis of love.

- Instead, I am simply asking you to do it because we (dual-incl) love each other and God's people.
- But I will only ask you, because I know you love me and your fellow believers.

I prefer: The phrase *I prefer* indicates that Paul wanted to appeal to Philemon on the basis of love instead of ordering him what to do.

to appeal: Paul was asking Philemon to do something. This was not the same as telling him to do it. And he was not asking a question.

on the basis of love: Rather than ordering Philemon to obey a command, Paul wanted Philemon to help Onesimus

because of love. But it is not clear who loved whom. There are three interpretations:

1. Philemon should do what Paul wanted simply because he loved Paul.
2. Philemon should do what he ought to do, not because of a command, but because he loved all of God's people.
3. Paul did not use his authority to tell Philemon what to do. The reason was: Paul loved Philemon. GNT follows this third interpretation.

All three interpretations are possible, and perhaps Paul was thinking about all these meanings when he wrote this passage. But the first interpretation seems most likely because of the following words in 9b. Verse part 9b implies that Philemon should show that he was thankful to Paul, an old man in prison. And he also should be thankful for Paul helping him to trust in Christ.

9b
For I, Paul, am now aged, and a prisoner of Christ Jesus as well.

- I, Paul, am asking you as an old man now, and as someone whom people have put in prison because I serve Jesus Christ.
- I do this as Paul—an old man, and now also in prison for the sake of Christ Jesus.

I, Paul: Paul was giving reasons why Philemon should agree to do what Paul asked him to do. For example:

- He was Philemon's friend, Paul.
- He was an old man.
- He was suffering because he trusted in Christ.

am now aged: The Greek word *presbutēs* has two possible meanings in this verse:

1. "old man" (BSB, NIV, JB, JBP, NLT, KJV)
2. "ambassador," a man who speaks for important people (GNT, NEB, RSV)

The phrase *am now aged* probably represents the right meaning in this verse because Paul had just said that he was not giving an order to Philemon, as a man of authority (verse 8) would do. Paul, as an *aged* man in prison for Christ (verse 9), was appealing to Philemon.

a prisoner: See notes on verse 1a.

Philemon 1:10

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

In this Section (verses 8–21) Paul, as a Christian brother, asked Philemon to help Onesimus, but did not command him to do it.

Read verses 8–21 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 8–11 Paul appeals to Philemon on behalf of Onesimus
Read verses 8–11 again, then read the following notes before you translate.

10a
I appeal to you for my child Onesimus,

- I am asking you to do a kind thing for Onesimus, who is like a son to me.
- I beg you to help Onesimus, who is like a son to me.

I appeal to you: Paul was asking Philemon to do something. See verse 9a notes. But Paul did not yet tell Philemon what he wanted him to do.

for: Paul was asking Philemon to do something "in regard to" Onesimus, or "on behalf of" Onesimus.

my child: Onesimus was not Paul's physical child. But he was like a son to Paul because, while Paul was in prison, he had helped Onesimus to believe in Christ. Just as a father helps give physical life to his son, Paul had helped give spiritual life to Onesimus.

Onesimus: The name *Onesimus* is a Greek word which means "useful, profitable, helpful" (see note on "useless" in verse 11). Many masters named their slaves *Onesimus*.

10b
whose father I became while I was in chains.

- He has become like my son while I have been in prison because I helped him receive new life from God.
- While I have been in prison I have become like his father.

chains: The Greek word *desmois* here means "bonds" or "chains." At the time Paul wrote this letter, the Romans often locked important prisoners in chains while they were in prison. Paul used *chains* as figurative language for being in prison.

Paul was in prison because he had been preaching the Gospel. But this does not mean that Onesimus was also in prison. He was probably only visiting Paul. If Onesimus, too, had been a prisoner, Paul could not have sent him back to Philemon (verse 12).

Philemon 1:11

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

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Paragraph 8–11 Paul appeals to Philemon on behalf of Onesimus
Read verses 8–11 again, then read the following notes before you translate.

11
Paul used these words in verse 11 to encourage Philemon to act favorably toward Onesimus.

11a
Formerly he was useless to you,

- In the past he was not useful to you because he ran away.

Formerly: This refers to the time after Onesimus ran away from Philemon and before Onesimus met Paul.

11a-b
useless…useful: The name Onesimus means "useful" (verse 10a). When Onesimus ran away from his master Philemon, he became *useless* (no longer useful) to him, which was opposite to what his name meant. But when Onesimus became a Christian, he became *useful* (helpful) again, so that the meaning of his name fit him again. See Display for verse 11a and 11b.

11b
but now he has become useful both to you and to me.

- But now he is useful to both of us.(dual-incl)

to you and to me: Onesimus helped Paul while Paul was in prison. And when Onesimus returned to Philemon as his slave, he would help him and obey him. So he now could be useful to both Philemon and Paul.

Philemon 1:12

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

In this Section (verses 8–21) Paul, as a Christian brother, asked Philemon to help Onesimus, but did not command him to do it.

Read verses 8–21 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 12–14 Paul sends Onesimus back to Philemon
In this letter, which Onesimus himself took to Philemon, Paul told Philemon that he was sending Onesimus back. Paul wanted Onesimus to stay with him and help him while

he was in prison. But he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon because Onesimus was Philemon's slave. It was Philemon, not Paul, who must decide whether Onesimus would come back later to help Paul while Paul was in prison.

Read verses 12–14 again.

12
I am sending back to you him who is my very heart.

- ¶ Even though I love Onesimus very much, I am sending him back to you.
- ¶ I am sending Onesimus back to you, he whom I love with all my heart.

sending back…him: The Greek word *anapempō* here means "send" or "send back." Paul used this word because Onesimus had come from Philemon, and Paul was sending Onesimus back to him.

my very heart: These words mean that Paul loved Onesimus very much and did not want him to leave. It was like he was sending away a part of himself. If you have an expression in your language that shows this kind of strong emotion, it would be good to use it here.

Philemon 1:13

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

In this Section (verses 8–21) Paul, as a Christian brother, asked Philemon to help Onesimus, but did not command him to do it.

Read verses 8–21 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 12–14 Paul sends Onesimus back to Philemon
In this letter, which Onesimus himself took to Philemon, Paul told Philemon that he was sending Onesimus back. Paul wanted Onesimus to stay with him and help him while he was in prison. But he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon because Onesimus was Philemon's slave. It was Philemon, not Paul, who must decide whether Onesimus would come back later to help Paul while Paul was in prison.

Read verses 12–14 again.

13
I would have liked to keep him with me, so that on your behalf he could minister to me in my chains for the gospel.

- I wanted to keep him here with me to help me while I am in prison for preaching the Good News about Jesus Christ. He could take your place helping me here, because I know that you want to help me.

I would have liked: "I would like" (GNT). You could freely translate the first part of verse 13 as "If I did what I wanted, I would keep him here." But Paul didn't do what he wanted to do for himself. He let Philemon decide (verse 14).

keep him with me: Paul wanted Onesimus to stay near him in the town where Paul was in prison so that Onesimus could visit him and help him.

on your behalf he could minister to me: Paul knew that Philemon wanted to help Paul in any way he could. If he had lived near Paul, he would have come to the prison and helped him. Philemon's slave Onesimus was there, and he could have helped Paul in Philemon's place, or on his behalf.

on your behalf: This means "instead of you, in your name, for you." Some other ways to translate it are: "what you would have done" (JBP), "take your place" (NIV), "as you would wish" (NEB).

in my chains: Another way to express the meaning of the phrase *in my chains* here, is "during the time I am in prison." See notes on verse 10.

for the gospel: He was in prison because he preached the Good News about Jesus Christ (see verse 1).

Philemon 1:14

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something

to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

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Read verses 12–14 again.

14a

But I did not want to do anything without your consent,

- But I am not keeping him here yet because you have not yet approved.
- But I don't want to do it unless you agree.

What Paul meant in this verse was that he did not ask Onesimus to stay with him, since Philemon was not there to approve of it. If he had asked Onesimus to stay, this would have been like forcing Philemon to let Onesimus help Paul. Paul may have meant that he wanted Philemon to send Onesimus back later so he could help Paul while Paul was in prison. But Paul wanted Philemon to do this only if Philemon himself wanted to do it, not because Paul said he must do it.

anything: The word *anything* here means "anything (in this matter about Onesimus)." Paul would not keep Onesimus with him and would not ask Onesimus to come back (to Paul) unless Philemon approved.

without your consent: Other ways to express this are "unless you say OK" or "without you saying it is all right." See Display for verse 14a.

14b

so that your goodness will not be out of compulsion, but by your own free will.

- I desire that any kind thing you do for me will be because you want to do it, not because I forced you to do it.
- I want your reason for doing any helpful thing for me to be because you want to do it, not because I caused you to do it.
- In this way, if you do what I ask, it will be because you want to do it, not because you have to.

so that: This phrase introduces the reason why Paul said in 14a "I did not want to do anything without your consent." The reason is in 14b: "if you agree to do what I ask, it will be because you yourself want to do it, not because I have said you must do it."

your goodness: Another way to state this is "If you help me like this…."

goodness: Paul was referring here to something kind or helpful Philemon might do for him. See " appeal" in verse 10.

not be out of compulsion, but by your own free will: If Philemon did a favor for Paul, Paul wanted it to be something Philemon himself decided to do, not something that Paul ordered him to do whether Philemon wanted to do it or not.

out of compulsion: When someone makes or compels you to do something, or forces you to some action.

by your own free will: This means "without someone telling you to do it." To do it willingly because you want to do it.

Philemon 1:15

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave

This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have

allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

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Read verses 8–21 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 15–16 Onesimus is now a brother in Christ
In these verses Paul said that it could be a good thing that Onesimus ran away from Philemon. As a result, Onesimus became a Christian. As he went back to Philemon, he went back not only as a slave, but also as a Christian brother. If he had not run away, he might not have become a Christian.

Read verses 15–16 again.

15a-b
for a while…for good: (GNT:) "short time…all time" The short time that Onesimus was away from Philemon—perhaps a few months—helped him to return and be with him for all time (on this earth and in heaven) as a fellow Christian. Another way to say this would be that Philemon lost a slave for a short time so he could get back a Christian brother for all time.

15a
For perhaps this is why he was separated from you for a while,

- ¶ It may be that God let Onesimus run away from you for a short time

perhaps: Paul was not certain that what he said in 15a–16a was God's plan, but he thought that it was likely.

was separated from you: What this really means is that Onesimus ran away. But Paul said it in a way that made it seem like God allowed him to run away or even that God caused this to happen. This then helped Onesimus to meet Paul and become a Christian.

15b
so that you might have him back for good—

- so that when he returns he can be with you again for all time.

have him back: This means that Philemon could have Onesimus with him again.

Philemon 1:16

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

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Read verses 15–16 again.

16a
no longer as a slave, but better than a slave, as a beloved brother.

- And from now on he will not be merely your slave. He is more than a slave. He is now your dear Christian brother.
- You should no longer consider him to be only your slave. He is more than a slave. He is now a fellow believer whom you can love.

no longer as a slave: This does not mean that Onesimus was not a slave any more. He was still Philemon's slave. It means that Philemon should not think of him only as a slave, but also especially as his Christian brother. GNT: "he is not just a slave."

slave: Onesimus belonged to Philemon because he was Philemon's *slave.* For more information on "slave", see Introduction to Philemon.

16b
He is especially beloved to me, but even more so to you,

- I love him very much, but you should love him even more.

even more so to you: Paul was saying that Philemon had a reason to love Onesimus even more than Paul did. This was because Onesimus would now be a faithful slave and a Christian brother to Philemon.

16c
both in person and in the Lord.

- You will love him as your slave and because he is a Christian brother.

in person: The Greek word that the BSB translates *person* here probably means that Onesimus was still a slave. But Philemon would be able to love him now as a person who would obey him and not run away.

in the Lord: This refers to Onesimus as a "fellow Christian," someone who was united to the Lord Jesus just as Philemon was.

Philemon 1:17

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

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Paragraph 17–21 Paul asks Philemon to welcome Onesimus back
In this paragraph Paul finally stated clearly to Philemon what he wanted him to do. He wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus back in the same way that Philemon would welcome Paul if Paul were visiting him. This is the main point of the whole letter.

Paul promised to repay Philemon for anything Onesimus may have taken from Philemon or for anything wrong he may have done against him. But Paul knew that Philemon probably would not ask him to repay him, because Paul had helped him to become a Christian. Christ surely changed the way Philemon thought about life and about money. In fact, Paul was sure that Philemon would do what he was asking him to do and even more.

Paul was also sending Onesimus back to Philemon because Onesimus needed to obey his master again and help him and show that he had changed. If Onesimus did this, he and Philemon could have peace with each other again.

Read verses 17–21 again.

17a
So if you consider me a partner,

- ¶ So, since you think of me as someone who works with you for Christ,
- ¶ Therefore, if you think of us (dual-incl) as people who work together,

So: Instead of saying *So*, Paul could have said "On the basis of what I have just said." (verses 8–16). This would mean the same thing. He could also have said, "Thinking of what I have just written to you."

if: Another way of expressing what Paul means by the word the BSB translates as *if* is "since" or "because." Paul often used the word *if* with this meaning. If you translated 17a as "I am not sure you consider me a partner," this would be the wrong meaning. Paul knew that Philemon thought of him as his partner. So he was saying, "Since you think of me as your partner."

partner: The Greek word *koinōnos* in this verse means "a friend who is a fellow Christian" (see verse 17 in LB, JBP). It refers to someone who works together with someone else to serve the Lord. This is very similar to the meaning of the term that the BSB translates as "fellow worker" in verse 1.

17b
receive him as you would receive me.

- welcome Onesimus back just as gladly as you would welcome me.

- when Onesimus comes back to you, treat him as kindly as you would treat me.

receive: To *receive* someone means to welcome him, to accept him gladly. Paul was asking Philemon to receive Onesimus back just as gladly as he would have received Paul.

Philemon 1:18

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
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Paul was also sending Onesimus back to Philemon because Onesimus needed to obey his master again and help him and show that he had changed. If Onesimus did this, he and Philemon could have peace with each other again.

Read verses 17–21 again.

18
But if he has wronged you in any way or owes you anything, charge it to my account.

- If he has done anything bad against you or if he owes you any money, let me pay for it.
- If Onesimus has wronged you or is in debt to you for anything, I will pay it.

It is not clear whether Onesimus did anything wrong except run away. But remember, Philemon was his master. Onesimus belonged to him. He did not have to pay Onesimus to work for him. When Onesimus ran away, Philemon may have had to hire another worker and pay him. So he may have felt that Onesimus owed him the money that he had had to pay the other worker. Onesimus may also have stolen something from Philemon, but Bible scholars are not certain about this.

owes: He needed to repay something to Philemon.

charge it to my account: This does not refer to a bank account. Paul did not have any kind of financial account with Philemon. Paul was saying, "Whatever Onesimus owes you, don't say he owes it but say I owe it to you." Paul was promising to repay to Philemon anything that Onesimus owed him. But the next two verses give reasons why Philemon would probably not let Paul repay him.

Philemon 1:19

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon.

He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

In this Section (verses 8–21) Paul, as a Christian brother, asked Philemon to help Onesimus, but did not command him to do it.

Read verses 8–21 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 17–21 Paul asks Philemon to welcome Onesimus back
In this paragraph Paul finally stated clearly to Philemon what he wanted him to do. He wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus back in the same way that Philemon would welcome Paul if Paul were visiting him. This is the main point of the whole letter.

Paul promised to repay Philemon for anything Onesimus may have taken from Philemon or for anything wrong he may have done against him. But Paul knew that Philemon probably would not ask him to repay him, because Paul had helped him to become a Christian. Christ surely changed the way Philemon thought about life and about money. In fact, Paul was sure that Philemon would do what he was asking him to do and even more.

Paul was also sending Onesimus back to Philemon because Onesimus needed to obey his master again and help him and show that he had changed. If Onesimus did this, he and Philemon could have peace with each other again.

Read verses 17–21 again.

19a
I, Paul, write this with my own hand. I will repay it—

- I am writing this in my own handwriting: "I, Paul, will pay you anything Onesimus owes you."

Bible scholars do not know if Paul wrote the rest of this letter with his own hand or if he only wrote this part. It seems that normally Paul dictated his letters to someone else who wrote them on paper. But a few times he wrote a small part of the letter himself, as he did here.

I, Paul, write this with my own hand. I will repay it: Paul emphasized that he was promising to pay what Onesimus owed to Philemon by writing the promise himself in his own handwriting. Another way of expressing this is like the GNT: "I, Paul, will pay you back."

19b
not to mention that you owe me your very self.

- But don't forget that you also are in debt to me for your new spiritual life because I helped you to become a Christian.
- You know already that, if I had not helped you, you would not have found new life yourself, so you owe me your own life.

Paul may have been smiling in the last part of verse 19. He probably knew that Philemon would not force Onesimus to repay him. He probably would not force Paul to pay anything, because Philemon owed something to Paul too.

In the middle of this last sentence in verse 19, Paul stopped referring to what he owed Philemon and started referring to what Philemon owed him. So the BSB uses a dash (—) to set the last part of this sentence apart from the text in the earlier part of the verse.

not to mention: This is a way of saying something that Paul didn't really want to say because he knew it might cause Philemon to feel a little ashamed. It was Paul's way of reminding Philemon of something Philemon already knew. There are other ways to translate the phrase "not to mention." For example: "I should not have to remind you, of course," (RSV), "I won't mention that" (NLT).

you owe me your very self: Paul had helped Philemon to become a Christian, and so Philemon owed his new spiritual life, his whole Christian life, to Paul. This meant that Philemon owed Paul much more than Onesimus owed Philemon. Another way to translate the Greek word *seauton*, "your own self," is "your very soul." Here are two alternate ways to translate this whole phrase:

> Your debt to me is big because through me you received eternal life.

> You owe a lot to me because I helped you believe in Christ.

Philemon 1:20

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Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

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Paul was also sending Onesimus back to Philemon because Onesimus needed to obey his master again and help him and show that he had changed. If Onesimus did this, he and Philemon could have peace with each other again.

Read verses 17–21 again.

20a
Yes, brother, let me have some benefit from you in the Lord.

- So, my brother, please do this kind thing for me because we (dual-incl) belong to the Lord.
- For the Lord's sake, my brother, please do for me this thing I am asking.

Yes, brother: Paul was again asking Philemon to welcome Onesimus. See verse 17.

some benefit: Paul was not asking Philemon to help him in some general way. He wanted Philemon to do a specific thing for him. He wanted him to forgive Onesimus and receive him back. So the meaning is clearer in the CEV: "do this for me" (referring to the favor Paul asked for in verse 17).

in the Lord: The main idea of this phrase seems to be that Paul wanted Philemon to think about Paul's request as a fellow believer in Christ would. And he wanted Philemon to think of Onesimus as a fellow Christian, not only as a slave. Paul believed that as Philemon thought like this, he would do what Paul was asking him to do.

20b
Refresh my heart in Christ.

- Encourage me by doing this as a fellow believer.
- Do what I ask because we both belong to Christ.

Refresh my heart: "Cheer me up," "make me happy," "set my heart at rest," "relieve my worry." Paul was saying, in other words here, what he already said in verse 20a. He used the same phrase here that he used in verse 7.

in Christ: This is the same kind of phrase as "in the Lord" (20a). Another way to say it is: "as a fellow Christian."

Verse 20b means the same as verse 20a. Paul was still saying that he wanted Philemon to do what he had asked him to do. Here are two ways to translate it:

> Make me happy as a Christian brother by doing this favor for me.

> Cause me to be happy as your Christian brother: do this favor for me.

Philemon 1:21

Section 8–21: Paul asks Philemon to accept back Onesimus, Philemon's runaway slave
This is the main part of the letter. Paul stated clearly in verse 17 what he was asking Philemon to do. He said, "Welcome Onesimus back just as you would welcome me." But before Paul asked Philemon to do this, he told Philemon several reasons why he should welcome Onesimus back. In verses 8–11, he told Philemon that he wanted him to do something to help Onesimus because Onesimus had become a Christian and would be useful to Philemon. Paul told Philemon that another reason why he should help Onesimus was because Philemon loved Paul and his other Christian brothers. In verses 12–14, Paul said that he was sending Onesimus back to Philemon, even though he wanted to keep Onesimus with him. In verses 15–16, Paul told Philemon why God may have allowed these things to happen, and that he (Paul) loved Onesimus very much. Then in verses 17–21, Paul finally said clearly that he wanted Philemon to welcome Onesimus. Paul offered to pay for anything Onesimus owed to Philemon. He also reminded Philemon that in the past he had helped Philemon become a Christian. This was another reason why Paul expected that Philemon would do what he asked.

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Paul was also sending Onesimus back to Philemon because Onesimus needed to obey his master again and help him and show that he had changed. If Onesimus did this, he and Philemon could have peace with each other again.

Read verses 17–21 again.

21
This verse is a summary of what Paul was asking Philemon to do for Onesimus. Paul believed quite strongly that Philemon would do what he was asking him to do. And Paul may also have been thinking as he wrote this verse that perhaps Philemon would cancel all of Onesimus' debt. See notes on verses 19 and 20.

21a
Confident of your obedience, I write to you,

- Even as I write to you, I am sure you will do what I asked.

confident: Paul meant, "I am sure," or, "I know." He was reassuring Philemon that he believed that Philemon would be willing to do what Paul was asking him to do.

your obedience: The Greek words translated *your obedience* literally mean "that you will agree to my request." Paul had said in verses 8 and 9 that he was asking Philemon to do only what Philemon chose willingly to do. He was not ordering him. The way the CEV translates it is probably closer to the actual meaning: "knowing that you will do what I ask you."

I write: Paul himself wrote the part in verse 19 but probably did not write the whole letter with his own hand. He usually had someone write for him while Paul told him what to write. Paul was saying here that he was the one who had chosen what words to put in the letter.

21b
knowing that you will do even more than I ask.

- Yes, I know that you will do even more than I asked.

even more than I ask: Paul believed that Philemon would do all that was right as a Christian. This meant not only doing what Paul asked, which was to accept Onesimus back, but doing more as well. Paul may have been thinking about two things when he said *even more*: (a) Perhaps Philemon would not force Onesimus or Paul to repay any of Onesimus' debts. And (b) perhaps Philemon would free Onesimus from slavery. But Bible scholars do not know whether Paul was thinking this, and they don't know if Philemon did either of these things.

Philemon 1:22

Section 22–25: Others greet Philemon
In verses 22–25 Paul wrote to the group of Christians who were with Philemon. So he used "you (plur)" in these verses as he did in verse 3. But in the main Sections of the letter (verses 4–21) he used "you (singular)" rather than "you (plur)." This is one thing that shows that verses 1–3 and verses 22–25 are separate from the other Sections of the letter. So verses 22–25, as a unit, are also a Section that is separate from the other parts of the letter.

After making his main point in the letter in verses 8–21, Paul finished the letter with a few final words in verses 22–25. He asked Philemon to prepare a guest room for him (verse 22), because he hoped that God would answer the prayers of the Christians at Colosse by allowing him to visit them again. Then Paul sent greetings to Philemon from five Christian friends who were there with Paul (verses 23–24). These peoples' names are also in Colossians 4:10–14. Finally, Paul ended the letter with a Christian blessing (verse 25).

Read verses 22–25 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 22 Paul asks Philemon to prepare for Paul to come
In this verse, Paul asked Philemon to get things ready for Paul to come and visit Philemon.

Read verse 22 again.

22a
In the meantime, prepare a guest room for me,

- ¶ And another thing: Please get a room ready in your house for me to stay in,
- ¶ While I am asking you to do something kind for Onesimus, I ask you to do something else for me. Please prepare a room in your house for me so that I can stay with you as a guest,

In the meantime: You could translate the Greek words here: "At the same time." For example:

> At the same time that I am asking this favor for Onesimus, I will ask another favor for myself.

prepare a guest room for me: Paul was asking Philemon to prepare a place for him to stay at Colosse. This would be a place in Philemon's house where Paul could sleep and where Philemon's servants could cook food for him. Paul apparently thought that the people who had put him in prison would soon free him from prison.

22b
because I hope that through your prayers I will be restored to you.

- because I hope that God will answer your(plur) prayers and cause people to release me from prison and let me come and see you(plur) again.

I hope that through your prayers I will be restored to you: Paul was not simply saying that he wanted to go and see Philemon and the Colossian Christians. He was saying that someone else—probably God—would need to cause this to happen.

Here are two examples of a free translation of this part of verse 22:

> I hope that God will make a way for me to become free so I can see you again.

> I hope that God will cause those who imprisoned me to free me so I can see you again.

I hope: Paul did not say that he was sure the Roman leaders would free him, but he wanted and expected this to happen. Bible scholars do not know whether Paul ever went to Colosse again or if he ever saw Philemon again.

through your prayers: Paul knew that the Christians in Colosse were praying that he would be able to leave prison. So he was saying that, if he became free, it would be because God had answered their prayers.

restored to you: Paul hoped that the people who had put him in prison would release him, and that as a result, he would be able to visit the Colossians.

to you: Paul used *you* (plur) two times in this verse. So here again he was writing not only to Philemon but also to the Christians at Colosse who worshipped God in Philemon's house.

Philemon 1:23

Section 22–25: Others greet Philemon
In verses 22–25 Paul wrote to the group of Christians who were with Philemon. So he used "you (plur)" in these verses as he did in verse 3. But in the main Sections of the letter (verses 4–21) he used "you (singular)" rather than "you (plur)." This is one thing that shows that verses 1–3 and verses 22–25 are separate from the other Sections of the letter. So verses 22–25, as a unit, are also a Section that is separate from the other parts of the letter.

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Read verses 22–25 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 23–24 Fellow believers greet Philemon
In verses 23–24 Paul sent greetings to Philemon from fellow Christians who were where Paul was. Consider how you would translate such a greeting into your language.

Read verses 23–24 again.

23
Epaphras, my fellow prisoner in Christ Jesus, sends you greetings,

- ¶ Epaphras greets you. He is in prison with me because he, too, serves Christ Jesus.
- ¶ Epaphras is a prisoner here with me because he preaches about Jesus Christ. He greets you.

Epaphras: This was a friend of both Philemon and Paul. Paul also wrote about this same *Epaphras* in Colossians 1:7, 4:12.

my fellow prisoner: There are two ideas about what this means:

1. a man who was in prison with Paul
2. a man who had been a prisoner like Paul was

The first meaning is probably the closest to what Paul was saying, because Paul sent greetings from Epaphras to the Colossian Christians. Since Epaphras was there with Paul as his *fellow prisoner*, it is more likely that he was in prison with Paul.

in Christ Jesus: Both Paul and Epaphras were in prison because of the Good News of Jesus Christ. Paul also referred to himself as "a prisoner of Christ Jesus" in verse 1. Paul was in prison because many people didn't want him to continue preaching about Jesus. Some commentators say that Epaphras went into prison so that he could help Paul. Others say that Epaphras was in prison because he also preached the Good News, and the phrase "my fellow prisoner" seems to imply this.

sends you greetings: Epaphras and the others whose names are in verse 24 asked Paul to send their greetings to

their friend Philemon. The *you* (singular) means that these friends were greeting Philemon as an individual person. It was their way of reminding Philemon that they still loved him and thought well of him.

Philemon 1:24

Section 22–25: Others greet Philemon
In verses 22–25 Paul wrote to the group of Christians who were with Philemon. So he used "you (plur)" in these verses as he did in verse 3. But in the main Sections of the letter (verses 4–21) he used "you (singular)" rather than "you (plur)." This is one thing that shows that verses 1–3 and verses 22–25 are separate from the other Sections of the letter. So verses 22–25, as a unit, are also a Section that is separate from the other parts of the letter.

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Read verses 22–25 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 23–24 Fellow believers greet Philemon
In verses 23–24 Paul sent greetings to Philemon from fellow Christians who were where Paul was. Consider how you would translate such a greeting into your language.

Read verses 23–24 again.

24
as do Mark, Aristarchus, Demas, and Luke, my fellow workers.

- And others here who help me as I work to proclaim the Gospel—Mark, Aristarchus, Demas and Luke—they also greet you.

as do: This means "these others also send you greetings."

Mark: This was John *Mark,* the Jewish Christian who wrote the Gospel of Mark. (Acts 12:25).

Aristarchus: Another Jewish Christian who was there with Paul was *Aristarchus*. His hometown was Thessalonica. (Acts 19:29).

Demas: *Demas* was a Gentile Christian, not a Jew. Bible scholars don't know if this was the same Demas who later left Paul (2 Timothy 4:10).

Luke: This was the same *Luke* who wrote the Gospel of Luke and the Acts of the Apostles. He was a Gentile Christian and a medical doctor (Colossians 4:14).

my fellow workers: These four men were working together with Paul, helping him in various ways to help people know about the Good News (see verse 1). Notice that Paul did not say they were his "fellow prisoners," as he said about Epaphras (verse 23). These four men were free to continue working with Paul to spread the Gospel, even though he himself was in prison.

Philemon 1:25

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Read verses 22–25 carefully in the BSB and the GNT.

Paragraph 25 Good-bye
Read verse 25 again.

25
The grace of the Lord Jesus Christ be with your spirit.

- ¶ May our(incl) Lord Jesus Christ bless you all.

grace: See notes on verse 3. Paul said again that he wanted the Lord to help and bless Paul's fellow Christians at Colosse, and he prayed for this. Verse 25 shows the way Paul ended many of his letters. (See 1 Corinthians 16:23, Colossians 4:18, 1 Thessalonians 5:28.)

be with your spirit: This does not refer to some *spirit* that was separate from the Christians Paul was writing to. He was talking about the people themselves. It is another way of saying "be with you." The word *your* is plural and shows that Paul wanted this grace or blessing to be with all the Christians at Colosse. Also the word *spirit* is singular (meaning "one spirit"). Paul was writing to them as one group of God's united people.